

Maine Climate-Safe Housing Policy Decision Matrix

Purpose

This report converts the town-level climate-safe housing MVP scores into planning actions. It is designed for state, regional, and municipal decision-makers who need to know where to start parcel screening, where resilience investment should come first, and where housing pressure is visible but infrastructure or hazard review must be strengthened.

This is still a planning-grade screen, not a permit map. The next GIS stage must ingest full FEMA NFHL, Maine Geological Survey sea-level-rise and storm-surge, wetlands, conservation land, DEM/slope, parcels, zoning, water/wastewater, road, bridge, and culvert layers before any final build/no-build conclusions.

Statewide KPI Snapshot

KPI	Value	Why It Matters
Populated Maine towns screened	518	Shows the statewide coverage of the MVP decision matrix.
Population represented	1,387,106	Estimates how many residents live in screened county subdivisions.
High housing-need towns	134	Towns where housing pressure should be investigated first.
High social-vulnerability towns	39	Towns where displacement, recovery capacity, and equity risk deserve attention.
Resilience-priority towns	93	Towns where public investment may need to come before or alongside housing growth.
Towns with sampled climate assets	57	Places touched by the first MaineDOT/DEP sample layers and needing deeper hazard review.
Near-term housing search towns	6	Best first-pass candidates for parcel-level suitability screening.
Hazard-overlay-first towns	3	Places where exposure review should precede growth claims.

Decision Rules

Action Category	Rule Used In MVP	Planning Meaning
Near-term housing search	MVP score ≥ 55 , infrastructure proxy ≥ 54 , vulnerability < 60	Start parcel-level suitability screening near existing service capacity.
Hazard overlay before growth	Sample climate asset count ≥ 5	Do FEMA/MGS/wetlands/conservation/DEM overlays before saying a town has safe growth land.
Resilience before or alongside growth	Resilience score ≥ 50 plus housing need or vulnerability signal	Pair housing policy with infrastructure hardening, recovery capacity, and equity investment.
Seasonal market stabilization	Seasonal housing share $\geq 25\%$ or seasonal lane assignment	Focus on year-round affordability, workforce housing, and anti-displacement tools.
Infrastructure capacity build-out	Housing need ≥ 50 and infrastructure proxy < 45	Housing need exists, but service/transportation/digital capacity may limit growth.

Action Category	Rule Used In MVP	Planning Meaning
Affordability and parcel screen	Housing need >= 60 outside stronger categories	Run parcel screening and local policy review for affordable housing production.
Monitor and screen after hazard layers	No strong MVP trigger	Keep in statewide database and revisit after complete hazard/environment layers.

Near-Term Housing Search Candidates

These towns have high MVP scores, stronger infrastructure-efficiency proxies, and social-vulnerability scores below the highest-risk band. They are not automatically safe to build; they are the best places to run detailed parcel screening first.

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Portland	Cumberland	68,854	73.04	67.34	43.12	84.36	35.78	8	Hazard overlay before growth
Lewiston	Androscoggin	38,324	66.36	70.39	57.61	62.55	42.33	3	Near-term housing search
Bangor	Penobscot	31,938	63.32	66.36	55.07	61.89	38.19	1	Near-term housing search
Waterville	Kennebec	17,077	60.04	68.00	57.31	56.03	38.70	0	Near-term housing search
Orono	Penobscot	11,902	58.40	72.05	49.86	54.28	36.32	0	Near-term housing search
Augusta	Kennebec	19,077	58.19	65.03	55.44	54.05	39.54	3	Near-term housing search
Auburn	Androscoggin	24,602	57.53	63.01	48.69	54.63	38.88	0	Near-term housing search
South Portland	Cumberland	26,930	56.66	56.97	36.60	65.01	28.21	9	Hazard overlay before growth

Resilience Before Or Alongside Growth

These towns show overlap between housing pressure, social vulnerability, recovery-capacity concerns, long commutes, digital gaps, or seasonal pressure. Housing work here should be paired with resilience investment.

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Eustis	Franklin	453	55.53	88.35	71.86	44.57	55.08	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
North Washington UT	Washington	620	52.06	83.69	72.17	37.52	59.68	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
West Paris	Oxford	1,808	51.14	74.95	61.55	35.99	55.93	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Cherryfield	Washington	809	50.09	71.82	68.72	31.99	58.47	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Allagash	Aroostook	224	49.72	90.09	72.25	21.61	72.52	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Orient	Aroostook	137	49.57	70.09	68.99	47.50	51.74	1	Resilience before or alongside growth
Winn	Penobscot	287	48.97	69.19	65.65	24.17	58.34	0	Resilience before or alongside growth

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Boothbay Harbor	Lincoln	2,096	48.38	73.17	59.66	44.29	50.51	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Crawford	Washington	97	47.89	69.61	73.08	39.48	59.15	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Norway	Oxford	5,228	47.76	65.95	57.33	38.02	50.95	2	Resilience before or alongside growth
Mattawamkeag	Penobscot	698	47.70	63.43	67.94	27.00	56.41	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Brighton	Somerset	98	47.52	85.01	63.16	25.82	69.46	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Livermore Falls	Androscoggin	3,102	47.38	62.84	55.54	28.94	51.70	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
North Penobscot UT	Penobscot	518	46.20	80.47	49.61	35.09	54.73	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Addison	Washington	1,045	46.20	68.29	60.48	34.22	53.76	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Lagrange	Penobscot	709	45.79	66.81	51.68	29.31	52.34	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Highland	Somerset	154	45.68	53.56	69.20	37.30	54.78	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Mount Chase	Penobscot	280	45.53	71.88	62.34	35.08	57.67	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Troy	Waldo	984	45.01	62.80	48.79	31.81	50.38	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
St. Albans	Somerset	1,831	44.69	73.00	62.38	23.31	66.11	0	Resilience before or alongside growth

Hazard-Overlay-First Towns

These towns intersect the first sampled Maine climate/infrastructure assets in the current MVP. This is a flag for deeper hazard overlay, not a final no-build finding.

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Portland	Cumberland	68,854	73.04	67.34	43.12	84.36	35.78	8	Hazard overlay before growth
South Portland	Cumberland	26,930	56.66	56.97	36.60	65.01	28.21	9	Hazard overlay before growth
Eastport	Washington	1,263	50.25	67.78	64.94	42.73	48.89	5	Hazard overlay before growth

Seasonal Market Stabilization

These towns require special attention to year-round housing, workforce housing, and displacement pressure from seasonal or second-home markets.

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Blue Hill	Hancock	2,813	46.46	71.45	43.88	45.03	45.32	1	Seasonal market stabilization
Lubec	Washington	1,346	46.22	64.40	56.71	43.98	47.16	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Phillips	Franklin	1,094	45.61	64.42	56.98	41.85	47.05	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Grand Lake Stream	Washington	169	45.15	69.64	51.47	43.48	45.41	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Harrington	Washington	917	45.10	65.29	50.82	42.91	42.75	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Southwest Harbor	Hancock	1,553	44.74	70.39	43.84	45.18	42.64	2	Seasonal market stabilization
Weston	Aroostook	275	44.73	67.66	55.75	41.58	48.18	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Castine	Hancock	1,362	44.56	69.84	40.71	47.32	42.32	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Brooksville	Hancock	853	44.30	69.40	46.58	43.47	45.16	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Islesboro	Waldo	636	43.53	60.75	50.81	48.65	42.13	1	Seasonal market stabilization
York	York	13,986	43.15	60.28	31.46	52.00	41.10	1	Seasonal market stabilization
South Aroostook UT	Aroostook	767	43.13	63.45	38.73	50.24	40.19	0	Seasonal market stabilization
North Haven	Knox	480	42.95	68.77	37.03	45.80	41.25	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Milbridge	Washington	1,222	42.95	61.41	51.98	39.46	47.81	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Trenton	Hancock	1,599	42.56	69.39	42.46	36.51	48.53	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Burnham	Waldo	953	42.20	63.09	44.14	41.06	44.17	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Frenchboro	Hancock	30	42.17	50.34	68.34	45.52	44.45	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Rockport	Knox	3,675	42.10	59.63	30.88	49.33	34.24	2	Seasonal market stabilization
Roque Bluffs	Washington	369	40.92	65.34	36.99	42.80	42.54	0	Seasonal market stabilization
Northport	Waldo	1,621	40.67	59.21	41.52	40.22	43.41	0	Seasonal market stabilization

Infrastructure Capacity Build-Out

These towns show housing need but weaker infrastructure-efficiency proxy values. The question is not only where to build, but what public capacity must be improved before growth can be equitable and efficient.

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Machias	Washington	2,020	55.47	71.18	60.05	43.84	42.61	2	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Van Buren	Aroostook	1,858	55.01	65.26	72.49	43.36	45.38	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Dexter	Penobscot	3,822	54.07	66.71	63.13	43.46	44.74	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Rumford	Oxford	5,942	53.45	70.36	61.42	40.51	47.68	1	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Belfast	Waldo	6,986	52.07	64.72	59.51	44.34	45.50	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
East Millinocket	Penobscot	1,495	51.91	64.65	59.68	44.05	41.43	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Skowhegan	Somerset	8,653	51.32	62.11	52.49	42.50	42.07	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Patten	Penobscot	1,154	51.19	63.62	66.79	40.75	49.89	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Guilford	Piscataquis	1,096	50.15	68.79	59.18	38.08	48.69	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Mexico	Oxford	2,782	50.10	64.15	56.35	38.11	45.15	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Calais	Washington	3,097	49.92	62.68	56.34	42.84	41.73	4	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Paris	Oxford	5,317	49.77	67.25	50.51	43.80	45.38	2	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Sherman	Aroostook	947	49.46	67.15	54.77	40.89	47.13	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Albion	Kennebec	2,204	49.24	59.93	53.03	42.16	41.34	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Farmington	Franklin	8,157	49.16	56.46	52.17	43.06	42.28	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Dennysville	Washington	218	48.83	66.80	59.50	34.64	49.21	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Wales	Androscoggin	1,924	48.57	62.40	45.53	44.64	39.75	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
St. John	Aroostook	180	48.43	67.97	57.99	38.46	47.89	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Howland	Penobscot	1,367	48.05	59.43	62.53	34.95	47.04	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Wilton	Franklin	3,862	47.96	61.41	52.23	40.06	44.47	0	Infrastructure capacity build-out

Highest Housing-Need Signals

This table answers the affordability-pressure side of the research question. These places should be tested against parcel availability, hazard exposure, and infrastructure capacity.

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Allagash	Aroostook	224	49.72	90.09	72.25	21.61	72.52	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Eustis	Franklin	453	55.53	88.35	71.86	44.57	55.08	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Brighton	Somerset	98	47.52	85.01	63.16	25.82	69.46	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
North Washington UT	Washington	620	52.06	83.69	72.17	37.52	59.68	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
North Penobscot UT	Penobscot	518	46.20	80.47	49.61	35.09	54.73	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Avon	Franklin	359	42.18	75.78	48.22	27.42	59.30	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
West Paris	Oxford	1,808	51.14	74.95	61.55	35.99	55.93	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
New Vineyard	Franklin	607	44.35	74.69	52.50	33.59	56.60	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Lee	Penobscot	925	43.47	74.06	54.68	29.60	59.20	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Kingman UT	Penobscot	138	41.73	73.21	57.18	23.31	62.15	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Boothbay Harbor	Lincoln	2,096	48.38	73.17	59.66	44.29	50.51	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
St. Albans	Somerset	1,831	44.69	73.00	62.38	23.31	66.11	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Orono	Penobscot	11,902	58.40	72.05	49.86	54.28	36.32	0	Near-term housing search
Mount Chase	Penobscot	280	45.53	71.88	62.34	35.08	57.67	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Cherryfield	Washington	809	50.09	71.82	68.72	31.99	58.47	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Chebeague Island	Cumberland	555	44.49	71.53	50.22	39.40	53.67	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Blue Hill	Hancock	2,813	46.46	71.45	43.88	45.03	45.32	1	Seasonal market stabilization
Machias	Washington	2,020	55.47	71.18	60.05	43.84	42.61	2	Infrastructure capacity build-out
Andover	Oxford	679	43.56	71.11	50.85	36.12	53.74	0	Resilience before or alongside growth
Madawaska	Aroostook	3,853	53.57	70.86	59.40	48.05	41.93	2	Affordability and parcel screen

County Portfolio Summary

County summaries help Maine agencies and regional planning organizations decide where technical assistance, hazard-layer completion, and housing planning support should be concentrated.

County	Towns	Population	Avg MVP	Near-Term	Resilience	Hazard First	Top Town	Dominant Action
Penobscot	65	154,710	41.05	2	11	0	Bangor (63.32)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Kennebec	30	126,808	41.29	2	2	0	Waterville (60.04)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Androscoggin	14	113,423	45.82	2	1	0	Lewiston (66.36)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Aroostook	70	67,058	39.59	0	11	0	Van Buren (55.01)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Oxford	38	59,255	37.24	0	11	0	Rumford (53.45)	Seasonal market stabilization
Somerset	37	50,959	36.35	0	11	0	Skowhegan (51.32)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Washington	48	31,331	41.32	0	9	1	Machias (55.47)	Seasonal market stabilization
Piscataquis	22	17,263	36.40	0	8	0	Guilford (50.15)	Seasonal market stabilization
Hancock	39	56,460	38.73	0	6	0	Bucksport (48.26)	Seasonal market stabilization
Cumberland	28	308,827	42.90	0	5	2	Portland (73.04)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Franklin	25	29,702	35.11	0	4	0	Eustis (55.53)	Seasonal market stabilization
York	29	216,731	41.44	0	3	0	Biddeford (52.64)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Waldo	26	40,192	40.47	0	2	0	Belfast (52.07)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Lincoln	19	36,099	37.70	0	1	0	Boothbay Harbor (48.38)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Sagadahoc	10	37,285	41.83	0	0	0	Bath (49.14)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Knox	18	41,003	40.28	0	0	0	Rockland (52.49)	Monitor and screen after hazard layers

Focus Towns Requested For Greater Maine Review

This table keeps the earlier user focus towns visible while the project expands statewide.

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Portland	Cumberland	68,854	73.04	67.34	43.12	84.36	35.78	8	Hazard overlay before growth
South Portland	Cumberland	26,930	56.66	56.97	36.60	65.01	28.21	9	Hazard overlay before growth

Town	County	Population	MVP	Housing	Vulnerability	Infra	Resilience	Assets	Primary action
Westbrook	Cumberland	20,775	52.09	51.15	33.55	61.29	25.84	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Brunswick	Cumberland	22,336	52.85	54.89	37.09	57.28	31.91	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Kennebunk	York	11,820	44.66	47.09	35.53	55.99	32.02	1	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Hollis	York	4,872	40.88	45.91	25.69	45.39	29.18	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Cumberland	Cumberland	8,647	44.10	43.07	23.24	57.86	23.93	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Falmouth	Cumberland	12,755	44.17	38.01	25.24	62.02	22.21	2	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Scarborough	Cumberland	23,215	50.86	50.58	28.85	65.24	26.64	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Gorham	Cumberland	18,300	45.45	39.38	26.05	57.79	23.73	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Biddeford	York	22,498	52.64	56.07	42.50	55.86	35.02	1	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Saco	York	20,819	50.97	53.19	32.27	58.81	29.20	1	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Bath	Sagadahoc	8,815	49.14	57.58	42.05	46.76	36.97	3	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Topsham	Sagadahoc	9,706	45.34	42.59	35.47	52.79	26.76	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Freeport	Cumberland	8,802	45.81	52.07	31.70	51.57	31.13	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Yarmouth	Cumberland	9,053	47.40	52.33	33.76	52.58	30.44	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Windham	Cumberland	19,188	42.94	41.11	23.93	55.24	27.32	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers
Standish	Cumberland	10,662	41.33	54.20	27.17	45.60	36.75	0	Monitor and screen after hazard layers

What This Answers For Maine

- Where can Maine start looking for climate-safe housing growth? Start with the near-term housing search towns, then run parcel-level hazard and environmental overlays.
- Which areas should avoid premature development claims? Any hazard-overlay-first town, coastal/riverine town, wetland-rich area, conserved-land area, steep-slope area, or infrastructure-limited town should not be labeled build-ready until full overlays are complete.
- Which towns combine housing need and vulnerability? Use the resilience-before-growth and highest housing-need tables to prioritize resilience funding, anti-displacement support, and recovery-capacity planning.

- Where should governments prioritize investment? Counties and towns with many resilience, hazard-first, and infrastructure-capacity flags should be first in line for technical assistance and capital planning.
- Which places are promising for affordable, infrastructure-efficient housing? Near-term housing search towns are the MVP starting points, especially where parcel overlays later confirm low flood, low wetland, low conservation, moderate slope, and service-access suitability.

Immediate Next GIS Tasks

1. Replace sample hazard flags with full FEMA NFHL, Maine Geological Survey SLR/storm-surge, NWI wetlands, conserved lands, shoreland, DEM/slope, parcels, zoning, roads, bridges, and culverts.
2. Convert the town matrix into parcel or 250-meter grid suitability scores.
3. Add scenario weights for policy choices: affordable housing, resilience-first, infrastructure-efficient growth, and conservation-first.
4. Validate results against local comprehensive plans, known flood events, and expert review from planners, emergency managers, housing authorities, and conservation staff.